

Lecture 1

Old Debates in a New World

2nd February 2026– BAIS

International Relations



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Key Debates and Readings

Questions to be considered:

- What are the important differences between IR and International Studies?
- How do Fukuyama, Huntington, and Kagan each define the trajectory of global politics, and where do their perspectives converge or diverge? To what extent are these frameworks still relevant, if they ever were, for understanding the world today?
- What is the role of non-Western powers in shaping the future of international politics in a post-Cold War, multi-polar world?

Required readings:

- Fukuyama, F. (1989). The End of History? *The National Interest*, 16, 3–18.
- Huntington, S. P. (1993). The Clash of Civilizations? *Foreign Affairs*, 72(3), 22–49. (After reading, it is strongly recommended to at least skim Henderson (2005) and/or Said (2001) below.)
- Kagan, R. (2007). End of dreams, return of history. *Policy Review* (Washington, D.C.), 144, 17–44.
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Contents



Course overview



**Trends in global
politics**



**Fukuyama,
Huntington and
Kagan**



Next week

Course Overview



The team

Lectures

Steven Denney

Sarah Wolff

Tutorials

Athanasios Stathopoulos

Arnout van Ree

Juliet Tinebra

Emma Cantal

Jung Lin

Jamaseb Soltnai

Objectives of the course

Introducing	Introducing students to international relations (IR) theories and contemporary global politics.
Outlining	Outlining traditional and critical approaches to IR, including realist, feminist, and postcolonial perspectives.
Exploring	Exploring key global issues, including migration, security, nationalism, global governance, and nuclear proliferation.
Developing	Developing a critical understanding of IR theories and global political challenges

International Relations vs International Studies

International Relations

Focus: Interstate relations and the international system

Themes: power, security, war

Theory: realism, liberalism, constructivism

Units: states (mainly), state actors, IOs, and non-state actors

Roots: political science, economics

International Studies

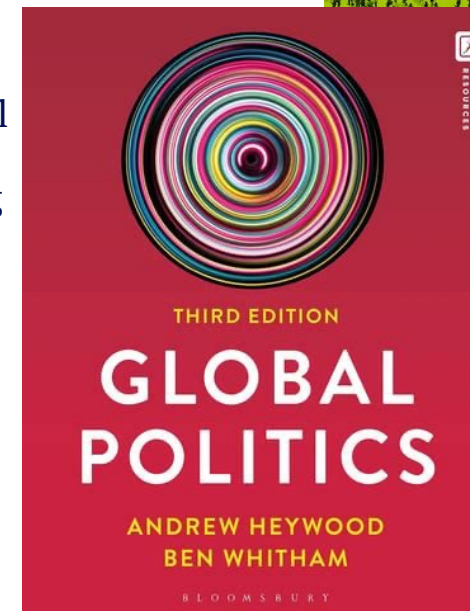
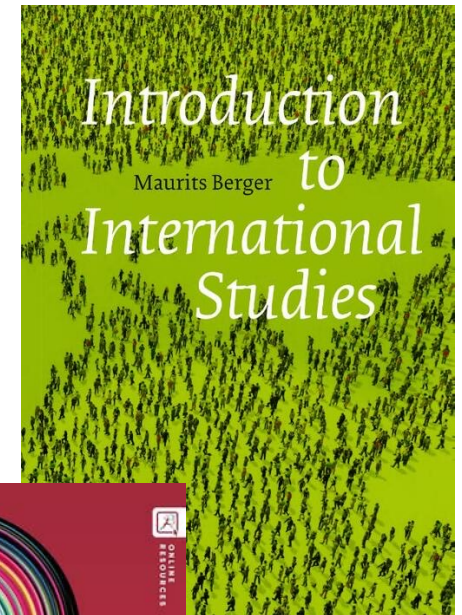
Focus: Global issues, with an emphasis on cultural and social dimensions

Themes: Globalization, development, human rights, migration, cultural exchange, and environmental challenges

Theory: Critical theory, post-colonial critiques, cultural and identity, feminism and queer theories (among others)

Units: wide range of actors

Roots: interdisciplinary



Stay engaged!



Attend lectures and tutorials.



Keep up with readings.



Discuss with your peers.

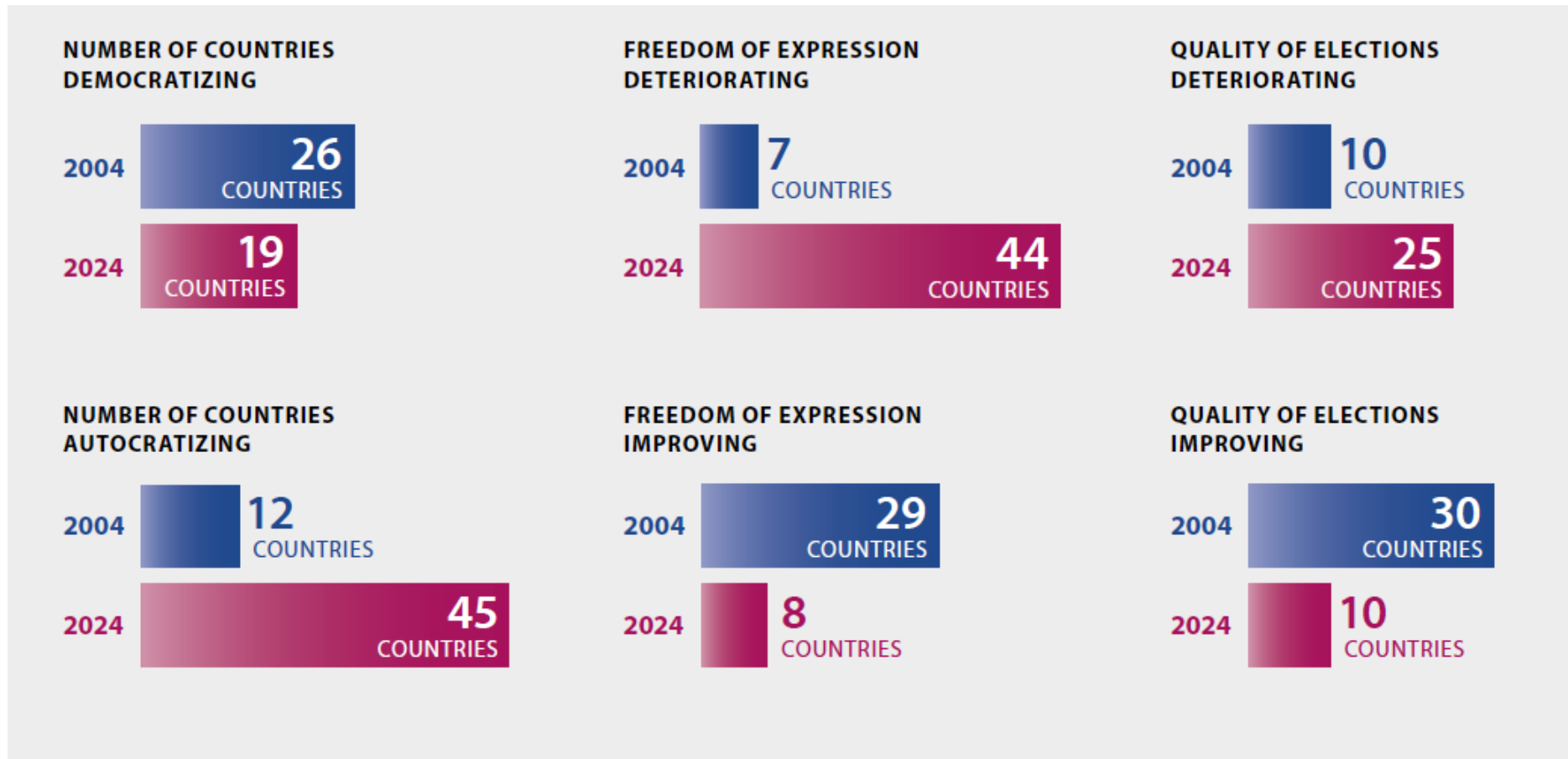


Follow current events but with *some* distance

Trends in World Politics



A wave of autocratisation



V-Dem Report 2025

Level of democracy for the average world citizen is back to 1985

It is a truly global wave of autocratization. Eastern Europe and South and Central Asia are in particularly steep decline. North America and Western Europe are also no longer immune.

The world now has 88 democracies (liberal and electoral) and 91 autocracies (electoral and closed) – a full reversal from the last year.

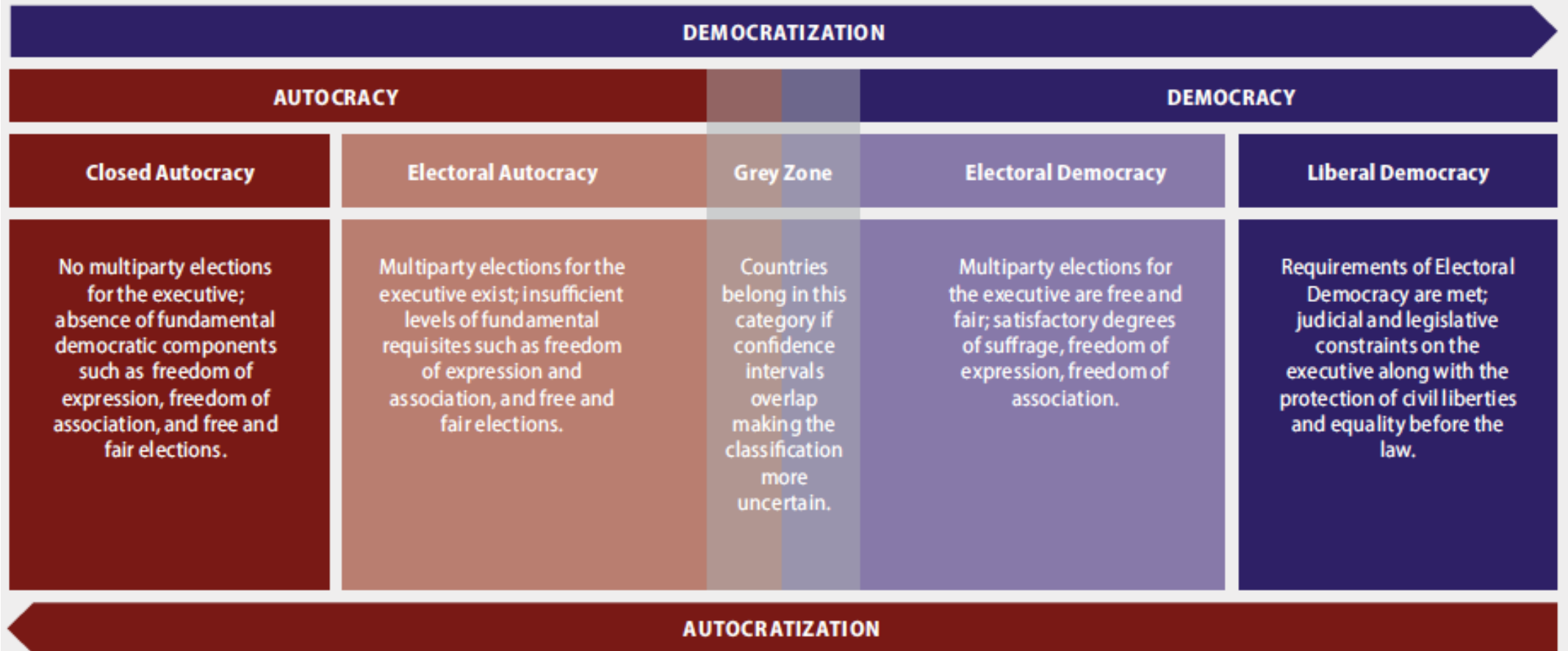
Liberal democracies have become the least common regime type in the world, a total of 29 in 2024.

Nearly 3 out of 4 persons in the world – 72% – now live in autocracies.

Attacks on **freedom of expression** continue at an alarming pace: Worsening in 44 countries by 2024, up from 35 in 2023.



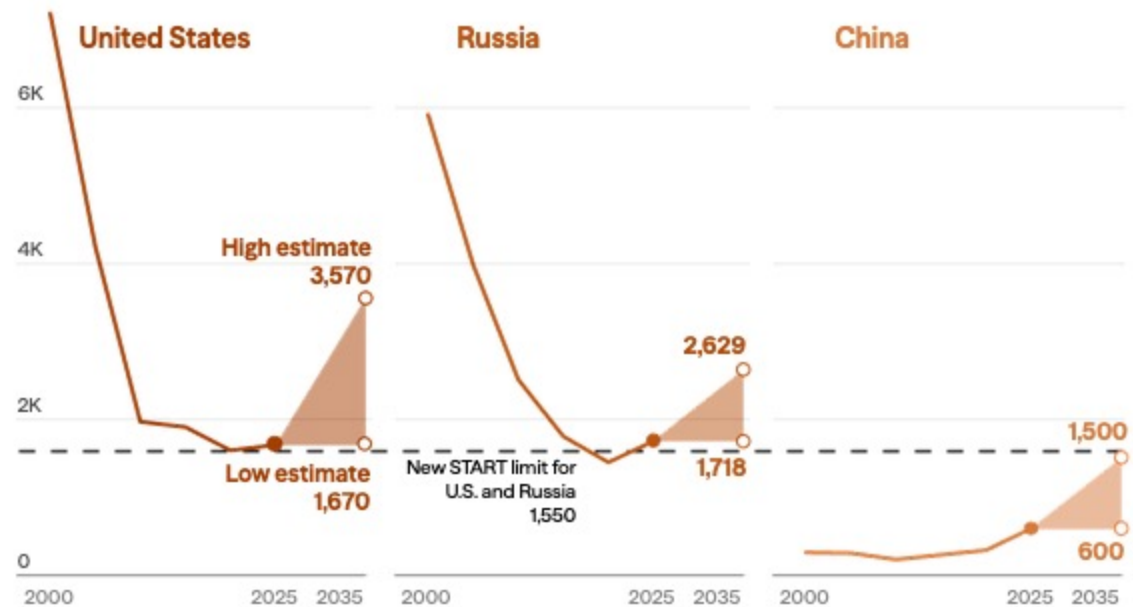
FIGURE 1. REGIMES AND REGIME CHANGE



The end of Arms Control

Soon the end of the
The New Strategic Arms
Reduction Treaty

Estimated and projected deployed strategic nuclear warheads



Note: According to open source experts, most Chinese nuclear warheads remain in storage but are assigned to operational land- and sea-based ballistic missiles and aircrafts.

Sources: SIPRI Yearbook; FAS

cfr

The Old Debates



We knew the story of the international rules-based order was partially false, that the strongest would exempt themselves when convenient, that trade rules were enforced asymmetrically, and we knew that international law applied with varied rigour, depending on the identity of the accused or the victim.

This fiction was useful, and American hegemony in particular helped provide public goods, open sea lanes, a stable financial system, collective security and support for frameworks for resolving disputes.

This bargain no longer works.

Let me be direct. We are in the midst of a rupture, not a transition.

Over the past two decades, a series of crises in finance, health, energy and geopolitics have laid bare the risks of extreme global integration. But more recently, great powers have begun using economic integration as weapons, tariffs as leverage, financial infrastructure as coercion, supply chains as vulnerabilities to be exploited.

Hegemons cannot continually monetize their relationships. Allies will diversify to hedge against uncertainty. They'll buy insurance, increase options in order to rebuild sovereignty — sovereignty that was once grounded in rules but will increasingly be anchored in the ability to withstand pressure.

This room knows this is classic risk management. Risk management comes at a price, but that cost of strategic autonomy, of sovereignty, can also be shared. Collective investments in resilience are cheaper than everyone building their own fortresses. Shared standards reduce fragmentations. Complementarities are positive sum.

So we're engaging broadly, strategically, with open eyes. We actively take on the world as it is, not wait around for a world we wish to be.

We are calibrating our relationships so their depth reflects our values, and we're prioritizing broad engagement to maximize our influence, given the fluidity of the world at the moment, the risks that this poses and the stakes for what comes next

And we are no longer just relying on the strength of our values, but also the value of our strength.

Our view is the middle powers must act together because if we're not at the table, we're on the menu.

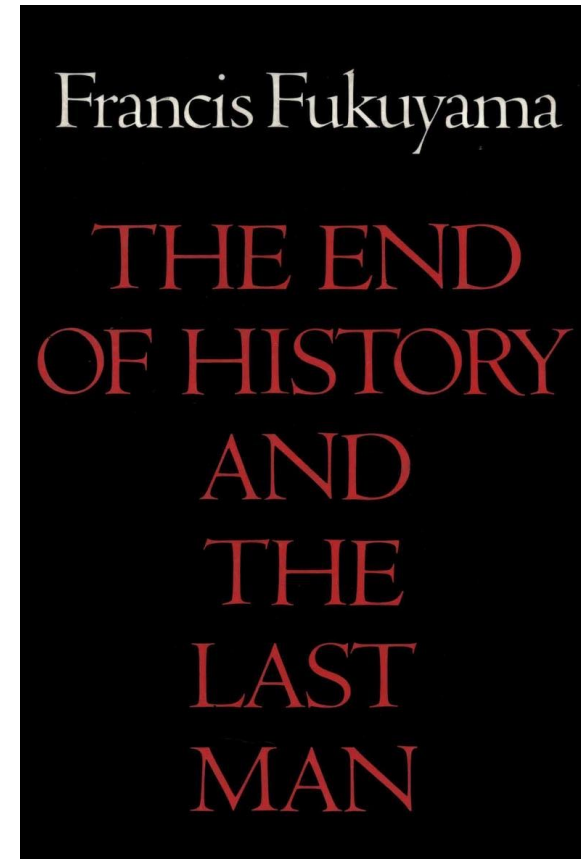
It means building what we claim to believe in, rather than waiting for the old order to be restored. It means creating institutions and agreements that function as described, and it means reducing the leverage that enables coercion.



Carney's Speech Davos, 20 January 2026

The end of History

- The American-led world order is there to continue
 - Popular End of the Cold War
 - It is the final stage of human ideological evaluation, communism (and earlier fascism) have been defeated- liberalism is dominant
 - all parts of the world would now irresistibly gravitate towards a single model of economic and political development, based on liberal democracy
- => Impact on the revival of the **democratic Peace Theory**



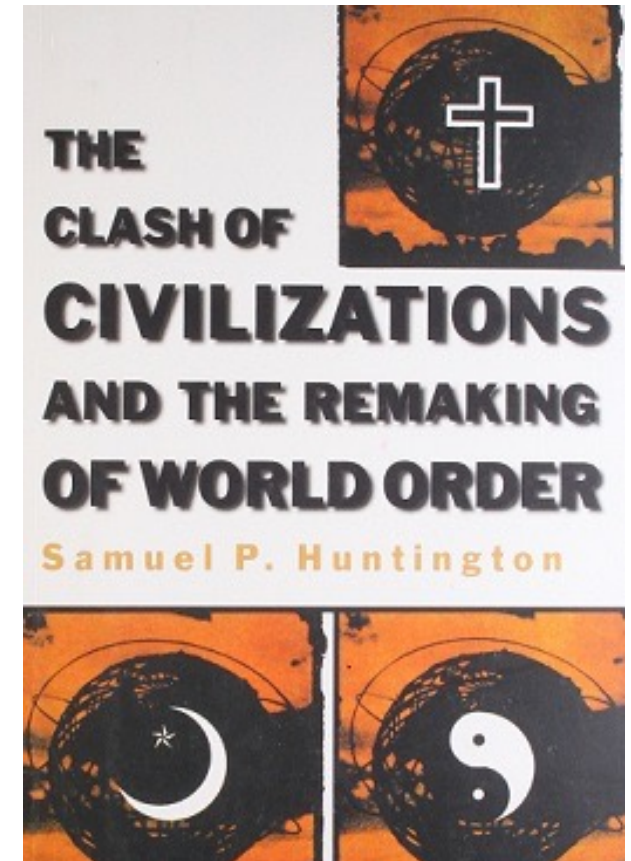
Influence on IR theory

- **Democratic peace theory/ Liberal peace theory:** Democracies do not fight each other, suggesting a long-term stabilization of world politics.
- **Institutionalism:** International institutions, built on liberal principles, would guide global governance and economic cooperation.
- **Economic interdependence:** Market-driven economies reduce the likelihood of war by fostering mutual benefits.

Huntington & The Clash of Civilisations

- Civilization and Culture should become the drivers of global conflict
- **Ideological or Economic conflicts are over**
- **Identity** matters at local, national, regional level
- Problematic as **essentialization and racialization** of the world order
- Came up with 7/8 major civilizations see p. 267 Textbook:

Western, Confucian, Japanese, Islamic, Hindu, Slavic Orthodox, Latin American and 'possibly' African

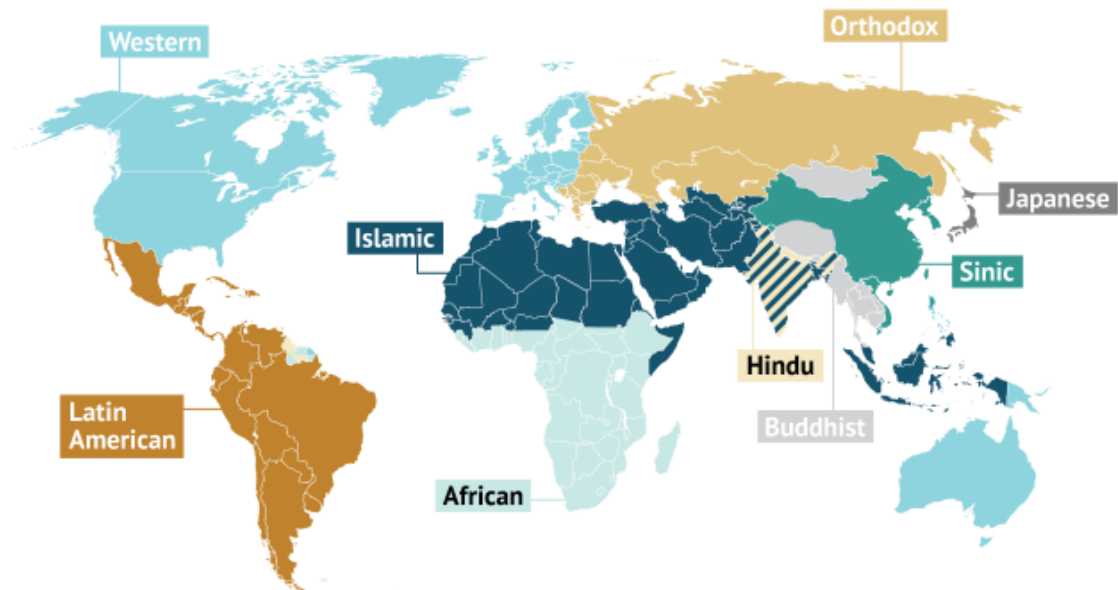


The problem's with Huntington's thesis

- The rise of civilization does not inevitably lead to conflict (Acharya, 2025: 360), indeed security ties between India and the US or
- There are far too many intra-“civilizational” clashes for the clash thesis to be true (Sunni-Shia, intra-“Confucian,” Russia-Ukraine, etc.)
- Rather than a “Clash of Civilizations,” we are witnessing a fragmented and multipolar world
- Other variables explain international conflict.
- Too simplistic vision of the world

HUNTINGTON'S CIVILIZATIONAL DIVIDES

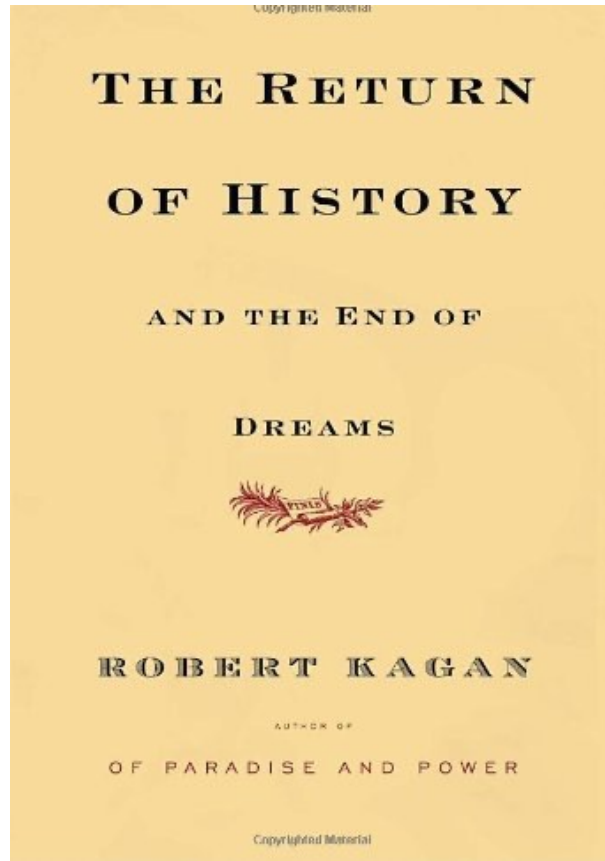
Samuel Huntington categorized the world into nine civilizations, arguing that the fault lines between them would shape international relations and serve as the driving force of conflict in the post-Cold War world.



Source: *The Clash of Civilizations*

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9/11 and the Return of History



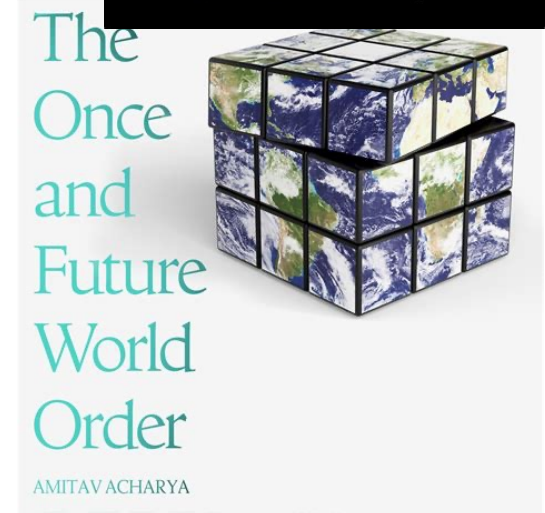
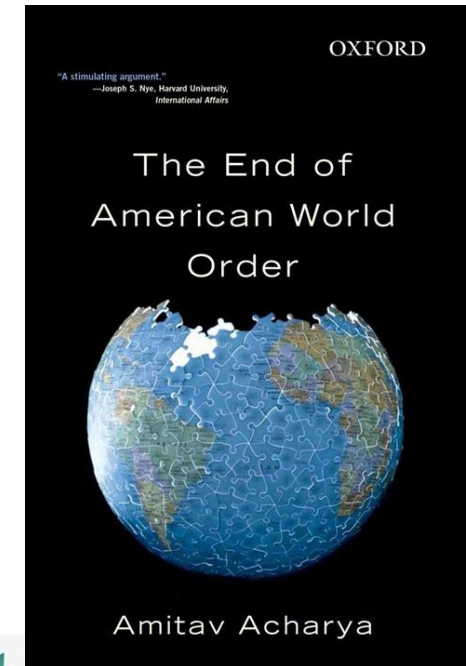
- The world has not been transformed.
- Traditional power struggles between nations, driven by ambition and competition, still shape global politics.
- The ideological struggle between liberalism and autocracy has (re)emerged as a defining feature of the present era.
- There is a lack of common political principles and shared morality among the great powers other than power. (contradicts point above?)
- The problem (p342 Textbook) 'tensions between democratic states (for example, tensions between the United States and the EU) and between authoritarian states (notably between China and Russia) may be just as significant as those across the democracy/authoritarian divide'

Comparison

	Francis Fukuyama	Samuel P. Huntington	Robert Kagan
Main driver of world politics	Ideology & political systems	Culture & civilization	Power, force, and geopolitical rivalry
Image of post–Cold War world	Convergence toward liberal democracy	Fragmentation into civilizational blocs	Return of great-power competition
Main argument	Liberal democracy vs. residual authoritarianism	Civilizational boundaries (West vs. Islam, Sinic, etc.)	Liberal order vs. revisionist powers
Role of the West	Model and vanguard of human political development	One civilization among others	Order-enforcer (especially the US)
IR theoretical affinity	Liberalism / Hegelian idealism	Constructivism (culturalist) with realist undertones	Realism / Neoconservatism
Main critique	Underestimates nationalism, religion, and power	Essentializes cultures; self-fulfilling prophecy	Normalizes militarism; underplays norms

Beyond the West- Amitav Acharya

- Future world order will not be dominated by one nation or civilization
- Neither the West nor the East will get to shape the future world order
- What matters is cultural and political diversity
- New forms of connectedness and stability
- **Multiplex world:** ‘where there are multiple shows on offer, giving the audience a choice of producers, directors, actors and plots (2025, 19)



Week 2, February 9– Power, Institutions and Ideas: Traditional IR Theories (Denney)

Questions to be considered:

What are the key assumptions underlying realism, liberalism, and constructivism in IR theory?
How do traditional IR theories explain the role of power and institutions in international politics?
To what extent do these theories explain major contemporary issues, such as the apparent decline of the Liberal International Order, Sino-U.S. competition, and Russia's invasion of Ukraine?

Required readings:

- Heywood, A., & Whitham, B. (2023). Global politics (3rd ed., Chapter 3: Traditional theories of global politics). London: Red Globe Press.
- Wendt, A. (1992). Anarchy is what states make of it: the social construction of power politics. *International organization*, 46(2), 391-425.
- Mearsheimer, J. J. (2019). Bound to fail: The rise and fall of the liberal international order. *International security*, 43(4), 7–50.

Thank you!



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